DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Makes One Day Holier Than Another?

Daat Tevunot §152-154

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §152-154
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 13 July 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The three energies again

We are in the middle of §152, in part 4 of Section 7. On Monday we saw that the flow of kindness and the flow of judgment exist together and balance each other. Hashem binds Himself to respond to that system, though He always has the "override button" of His sovereignty.

The Ramhal sums up the three kinds of divine energy:

1. **Pure materialism,** which makes the lowly worlds and creatures.
2. **Pure spirituality,** where everything is holiness. This is the level of angels, and it is not what we have.
3. **A combination,** which brings spiritual light into the physical without refining it away. It is lower than the second, but it is still light.

Then he describes the order in which they were made. Hashem first made the fully spiritual energy. From it He made a lesser one that sanctifies but does not erase the darkness. Then He made pure darkness. Finally He combined them in different measures as He wished, sometimes more of one and sometimes more of the other. That is why even physical people still long for spiritual things.

A participant was confused by the numbering, and the Rabbi straightened it out. The first list gave the two extremes and the middle. The second paragraph explains how the middle came about, by mixing the lesser light into the darkness.

Time, place and the person

How much light is in the mixture, "fifty-fifty or ninety-ten"? The Rabbi said it depends mostly on time and place, and within those, on each person's own work.

The holy days

With this the Ramhal explains the holy days. On a holy day more of the second, purer light is mixed into the physical. But it is never the pure light itself, or all darkness would vanish and there would be no choice.

The Rabbi brought a measure from Derech Hashem: the holiness of a day matches the number of people called to the Torah.

- Shabbat: seven aliyot. Shabbat is holier than Yom Kippur. The proof is that desecrating Shabbat is punished by stoning, while breaking Yom Kippur carries karet.
- Yom Kippur: six.
- Yom Tov (Rosh Hashanah, Sukkot, Pesah, Shavuot): five.
- Rosh Hodesh and Hol HaMoed: four.
- Purim and Hanukkah: three, the same as Monday and Thursday, which is why people used to fast on those days.

Days like Tu BiShvat or Tu BeAv are lovely days, and Tahanun is not said on them, but they have no holiness of the day in this sense.

What about Purim?

A participant raised the saying that Purim is one of the holiest days. The Rabbi explained that it is the Zohar that compares Yom Kippur to Purim ("Yom Kippurim", a day like Purim), and usually the lesser thing is compared to the greater. "Does that really make sense? Purim greater than Yom Kippur? Obviously not." On Purim one may work and drive. The statement must belong to a different level. There may be one aspect in which Purim is greater, but "you can't compare the two" overall. His general warning: "You don't just take a statement and build a framework out of that."

Climbing back

The Ramhal reminds us that man fell after Adam's sin. Adam's spiritual level after the sin was the level of his physical body before it. First we must fill this world with more light within its present state and return to Adam's highest level before the sin, and only then go further, "elevation after elevation". The Neshamah then says (§153) that this is very important, which ends part 4.

Part 5: judgment comes from love

Part 5 (§154) turns from what Hashem does to the world to the love behind it. Part 5 and part 6 deal with love, and Section 8, after the summer, will deal with how we receive all this.

The Ramhal says that chastisement itself comes from love. We spend the most time telling off the children we love most, and a true friend tells you when you are going wrong. Like a father who loves his son and cannot bear to see bad traits in him, Hashem teaches us gently until our path is straight.

Hitting a child

The Rabbi brought a ruling of Rav Moshe Feinstein. The Torah limits lashes to 39, and from this we learn that striking anyone is forbidden by the Torah. So how may a parent ever smack a child? He added that it is forbidden to hit a child over bar or bat misvah age, in case the child hits back and incurs a grave sin, which would be "placing a stumbling block before the blind".

Rav Moshe answers that the Torah forbids striking that does not come from love. A smack given in frustration, to vent one's anger, is forbidden and also does not work. A parent who calmly sits the child down after the child has run into the road, explains how dangerous it was, and then gives a smack "because I love you" is acting out of love. Hashem acts the same way.

So from the same love that wants to give us good, Hashem also chastises us, always "the left hand pushes away and the right draws near". From love come three things: pure kindness, judgment, and mercy that tempers the judgment. The class ended here, to continue with the 13 attributes on Monday.

Summary

- Three energies: pure matter, pure holiness, and a mixture of light within darkness, in varying measures.
- The holiness of a day depends on how much light is mixed in, and the number of aliyot reflects it: Shabbat is holier than Yom Kippur.
- One statement, such as the Zohar on Purim, should not be turned into a whole framework.
- Judgment comes from love, like a loving parent's discipline. Discipline in anger is not love and is not permitted.
- From love come kindness, judgment and mercy: "the left pushes away and the right draws near".

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/aNUr28N-Opc · More shiurim: rabbikada.com